

LAKSHMI *KATAKSHA*, FOR JANARDANA!

She hasn't quite stormed into politics yet; but she has already created a stir in the political circles of Karnataka, with her grit, determination, fighting spirit, organisational acumen, and – most importantly – her spiritual conviction

Lakshmi Aruna, wife of business tycoon and Gangavathi MLA Janardana Reddy, could have passed off as any ordinary woman had life not put her through a hard grind. That she has endured the toughest of times and has fought her way through crisis after crisis to ensure her husband's position in public life, is a testimony to the steel that she is made of.

When almost all of Janardana Reddy's fair-weather friends and relatives seemed to have deserted him and when the political corridors were already writing him off, Lakshmi jumped in to fight for him.



It may seem natural – and may even have become a norm these days – to see the wives of beleaguered men going on a temple run, but Lakshmi Aruna's wasn't just a run to seek divine blessings; it was a spiritual sojourn as well as political rediscovery.

Reddy had been sentenced to 7 years imprisonment last month by a trial court, in a case pertaining to his mining company, OMC. As an immediate consequence, he had lost his MLA post, too. A strong enough jolt to drive the strongman's strongest team astray.

But that's when Aruna stood up. Among the first things she did was to galvanize the flock again, give the party workers the confidence that the sentence was just a temporary blip, make them believe that their leader would be back soon. She also carefully put together the legal aspects to fight and engaged best legal minds to go on an appeal against the sentence.

Only after this that her spiritual sojourn started. It began with a visit to Sri Anjanadri, the birthplace of Lord Hanuman, and then proceeded to the Pattabhirama Temple to take a solemn vow of scripting one crore copies of the Sundarakanda from the Ramayana — a powerful act of faith and conviction. It was followed by visits to Udupi Sri Krishna, Kolluru Mookambika, Maranakatte Brahmalingeshwara, Kamakhya Devi (Assam), and Ghati Subramanya Temples.

Almost as an answer to her prayers, Reddy was released on bail soon after by the Hyderabad High Court. He is now back as MLA.

Although she hails from a political family in Andhra Pradesh, Lakshmi had never plunged herself into politics till the 2023 Karnataka Assembly elections, when she lost her electoral debut from the Ballari City constituency.

But now, the world knows that she is here to stay.